Data through **30 Sep 2026.**
Source: NHTSA vehicle owner complaints, downloaded 15 Oct 2026.

Accuracy: **Random check** of 200 random complaints found 69% assigned to exactly the right problem and **93% to the right or a closely related** one.

Krisztián Kerényi

Recurring problems in 84,000 Ford owner complaints

NHTSA public complaints, January 2020 to September 2026. Free text grouped into 68 problems with local embeddings, clustering and an LLM, then reviewed.

Complaints analysed	Complaints in a recurring problem	Share held by the top 10 problems	Owners waiting for recall parts
84K	90.3%	53.5%	9.3%

Quick insights:

Waiting for **recall parts is the fastest growing complaint** type: **backup camera parts +83%**, delayed **recall repairs +75%** (last 12 months vs the 12 before).

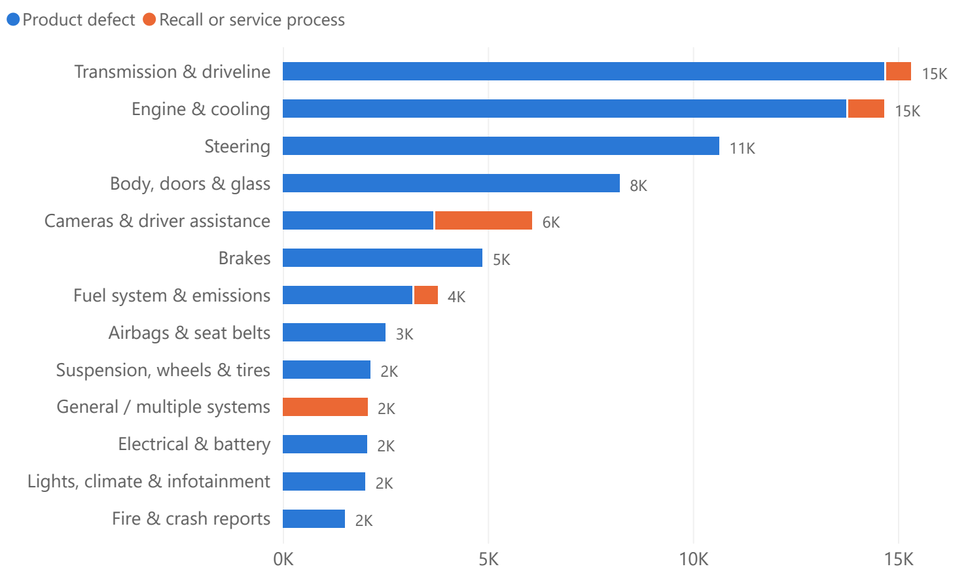
Coolant leaking into the cylinders and **power steering failures** are the two biggest problems, **21% of assigned** complaints together, but both fell by more than 40%.

Brake pedal and fluid leak complaints **rose 21%** and have the h**ighest crash, fire or injury share** in the top 15 (4.8%).

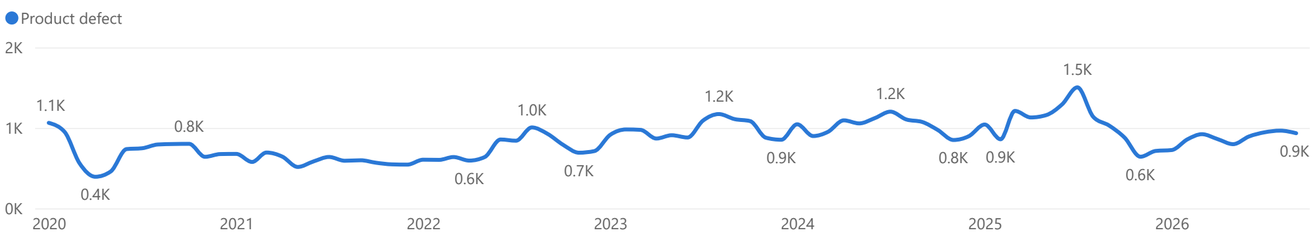
Top 15 recurring problems

Problem	System	Complaints analysed	Cumulative share	Crash, fire or injury	Change, last 12 months
Coolant leaks into cylinders, engine needs replacing	Engine & cooling	8,920	11.8%	0.9%	-41.1%
Power steering assist fails while driving	Steering	7,041	21.1%	2.3%	-43.5%
Transmission slips, shifts hard or fails	Transmission & driveline	4,796	27.4%	0.9%	-0.9%
Brake pedal sinks to floor, brake fluid leak	Brakes	3,677	32.2%	4.8%	20.7%
Transmission unexpectedly downshifts	Transmission & driveline	3,633	37.0%	0.9%	-10.3%
Violent front-end shaking after bumps (death wobble)	Steering	3,036	41.0%	1.3%	-56.2%
Backup camera image blank, distorted or flipped	Cameras & driver assistance	2,621	44.5%	2.7%	-18.8%
A-pillar trim detaches from windshield	Body, doors & glass	2,463	47.7%	0.4%	-39.4%
Recall parts unavailable: backup camera	Cameras & driver assistance	2,419	50.9%	2.1%	82.5%
Vehicle hesitates or loses power when accelerating	Transmission & driveline	1,965	53.5%	1.7%	-43.6%
Recall repair delayed or ineffective	General / multiple systems	1,526	55.5%	2.9%	74.6%
Door latch fails, door does not stay closed	Body, doors & glass	1,360	57.3%	1.5%	-25.1%
Gear shifter cable bushing detaches	Transmission & driveline	1,351	59.1%	3.8%	-23.8%
Transmission lead frame causes violent downshift	Transmission & driveline	1,284	60.8%	1.9%	14.3%
Cam phasers fail causing rattling sound	Engine & cooling	1,135	62.3%	0.4%	-77.4%

Complaints by system



Product defect complaints per month



Waiting for recall parts or repair, per month

